wearing of gold and silk dresses [at prayer-time]' agreed Badauni, 'was made obligatory.'

The kar khanas of the empire were kept busy all year round supplying robes and dresses for the Mughal court. Every year, a thousand complete suits (sar-o-pa, head to toe) were made for the imperial wardrobe, some for the Padshah and some to be given as gifts to noblemen. At any given time, 120 new robes were kept in readiness. The materials used for these qabas, payjamas, turbans, and overcoats included silk, zarbaft (cloth woven using golden thread), kamkhwab (cloth made of gold), tiladoz, mukkeshkar, and muslin from Malwa. Deccani muslins were reputed to be so fine that they were invisible when floated on water. An item of clothing which became popular at this time was the patka, which Akbar named the katzeb, or waistband. It was a simple, narrow band of cloth wound around the waist with the two ends hanging in front. With Akbar's successors, this patka would become very elaborate, detailed, and intricately embroidered. Akbar himself remained fairly austere in the way he dressed, often wearing fine white muslin shot through with gold thread. The gorgeous robes he wore on the occasion of his birthday, however, took the tailors a whole year to complete.

In September 1582, Acquaviva wrote about a new festival called Merjan (Persian Equinox) that was celebrated at Fatehpur Sikri. When Acquaviva questioned the court astrologers about it, he was told that 'it was a feast which the ancient Kings of Persia, who worshipped fire, used to celebrate'. Akbar ordered that 'all the captains (noblemen), should dress in festal attire, and there was native music and dancing'. Akbar had new coins stamped with 'Era of the Thousand' written on them and had a new history commissioned, the *Tarikh-i Alfi*, beginning with the death of the Prophet. These unusual celebrations and changes introduced to the court were noted with some bemusement by the Jesuits but it was Badauni who kept the most scandalized record of them.

He wrote his clandestine biography of Akbar long after his career at court had floundered hopelessly. It was brought out after he died in 1614 and was banned by Jahangir for being too shocking; Jahangir also had Badauni's sons arrested for good measure. For Badauni, these 'millennial celebrations' were the result of Akbar believing he could now openly criticize orthodox Islam and propose new, heretical alternatives as 1,000 years had elapsed since Prophet Muhammad's birth, and a new millennium